

REMARKS BY THE CHAIRMAN OF THE CRHP

Pharm. Ahmed T. Mora, mni

Presented at the Retreat of Members of the Committee of Registrars of the
Health Professions (CRHP)

Yankari Game Reserve, Bauchi State, January 18–19, 2011

My Dear Colleagues

Preamble

It is my pleasure to welcome every member of the Committee of Registrars of the Health Professions (CRHP) to our third retreat here at the famous **Yankari Game Reserve, Bauchi State**. This retreat includes four new members who joined the CRHP since our last gathering at **Obudu Cattle Ranch and Resort, Cross River State, on October 7–8, 2009**. These are:

- Mr. Shiono Bennibor – Registrar/CEO, Community Health Practitioners Registration Board of Nigeria (CHPRBN)
- Mr. Samuel Akume – Registrar/CEO, Dental Therapists Registration Board of Nigeria (DTRBN)
- Prof. David Segun Oluleye – Registrar/CEO, Institute of Public Analysts of Nigeria (IPAN)
- Prof. Anthony Emeribe – Registrar/CEO, Medical Laboratory Science Council of Nigeria (MLSCN)

Included in our agenda is a dinner in honor of **five retired members**: Mallam Bashir Umar, Mrs. Mabel John, Alhaji Bola Haruna, Lady E. U. Okonkwo, and Dr. Rowland Eyime. We congratulate them on their distinguished service and wish them happy retirement, hoping that we, too, may exit our duties with the same honor.

This retreat is organized by **GSCL Consulting, Abuja**, a multidisciplinary firm specializing in advisories, performance improvement, and outsourcing. The theme is:
“The Need for Minimum Standards of Practice by Health Regulatory Agencies as an Instrument for Assuring Effective Health Care Regulation in Nigeria.”

Health care professions are dynamic worldwide, as are their regulations, which remain our primary responsibility. In a fast-changing national environment, measurable standards are essential for Councils, Boards, and Institutes to evaluate the quality of the health care professions they regulate. This understanding informed the choice of our retreat topic.

Additionally, the public, whose health care we regulate, deserves the highest standards as professional practices become increasingly sophisticated. We look forward to learning and discussing these concepts with the Consulting Firm.

History of Our Retreats

The **first CRHP retreat** was held in Asaba, Delta State, on **April 10–13, 2008**, in honor of Dr. Rowland Eyime, then the Honourable Commissioner for Science and Technology, Delta State, and former Registrar of the Optometrists and Dispensing Opticians Board of Nigeria. The theme was: **“Brainstorming on Ways to Improve Health Care Delivery Services in Nigeria.”**

The **second retreat** took place at Obudu Cattle Ranch and Resort, featuring Prof. W. O. Aiyepoku, an international consultant, who presented on: **“Empowering Knowledge Workers for Organizational Success: The Advantages of a Knowledge Management-Savvy Workforce.”**

Our **first workshop** was on **July 29, 2008**, at the Sheraton Hotel, Abuja, themed: **“The Role of Health Regulatory Bodies in Advancing Healthcare Delivery Services in Nigeria.”**

Capacity-building initiatives extended internationally. In **Geneva, Switzerland (February 18–19, 2010)**, some members attended the **Second World Health Professions Conference on Regulations**, organized by the **World Health Professions Alliance (WHPA)**, with the theme: **“Shaping the Future: The Regulation of Health Professionals.”**

These efforts underscore the importance of equipping ourselves with the latest professional knowledge. As custodians of laws governing health professions, we must model **Continuous Professional Development (CPD)** for our members.

Currently, a request is before the Honourable Minister of Health for approval for members to attend a **2-week Professional Development Programme in Strategic Development Policy** at **Liverpool Hope University, UK (February 14–**

25, 2011). We remain hopeful for approval, as was granted for the Geneva event in 2010.

Responsibilities as Registrars

Since 1999, public service reforms in Nigeria have increased the demand for effective positioning of our Registries, requiring us to execute our regulatory and control functions efficiently. As I stated on **October 8, 2009, at Obudu**:

“The recent structural reforms in Nigeria’s Public Service have placed huge responsibilities on our shoulders that must be confidently and efficiently discharged, especially regarding our new powers of procurement. Our enhanced responsibilities and status place us in the spotlight, attracting potential envy and scrutiny from professional associations, staff, and members of our Governing Councils, Boards, or Institutes.”

These observations remain relevant today. Some of us have faced challenging times with staff, professional associations, or governing bodies. While critics will always critique, CRHP provides a platform to **share ideas, learn from each other, and enhance health care services in Nigeria**.

An effective health care delivery system requires a mix of professional expertise. With cooperation and shared knowledge, we can meet these challenges.

I wish all participants a **successful and fruitful retreat** here at **Yankari Game Reserve**, Nigeria’s foremost game reserve. From Abuja, Lagos, Asaba, Obudu, to Geneva, our past retreats have been successes. This retreat will be no exception. **Next stop: Liverpool.**

Thank you for your attention, and God bless.

Pharm. Ahmed T. Mora, *mni*

Registrar, PCN and Chairman, CRHP

January 19, 2011

The Health Regulatory Agencies as Instruments for Professional Harmony in Nigeria

Sheraton Hotel, Abuja – Thursday, March 31, 2011

1.0 Introduction

Health Regulatory Agencies in Nigeria operate under the **Federal Ministry of Health (FMOH)** and were established by Acts of the National Assembly to regulate and control the training and practice of health care professions. Presently, there are **thirteen such agencies**:

1. Pharmacists Council of Nigeria (PCN)
2. Medical and Dental Council of Nigeria (MDCN)
3. Institute of Public Analysts of Nigeria (IPAN)
4. Medical Laboratory Scientists Council of Nigeria (MLSCN)
5. Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria (NMCN)
6. Institute of Chartered Chemists of Nigeria (ICCON)
7. Dental Therapists Registration Board of Nigeria (DTRBN)
8. Medical Rehabilitation Therapists Registration Board of Nigeria (MRTB)
9. Optometrists and Dispensing Opticians Registration Board of Nigeria (ODORBN)
10. Dental Technologists Registration Board of Nigeria (DTRBN)
11. Radiographers Registration Board of Nigeria (RRBN)
12. Health Record Officers Registration Board of Nigeria (HRORBN)
13. Community Health Practitioners Registration Board of Nigeria (CHPRBN)

Each agency is headed by a **Registrar (CEO)** appointed as a public officer of the Federal Republic of Nigeria (FRN). The agencies also have **Governing Councils or Boards** with distinguished professionals under a Chairman appointed by the President, Commander-in-Chief of Nigeria.

- The **Pharmacists Council of Nigeria (PCN)** has the largest Governing Council with 63 members.
- The **Community Health Practitioners Registration Board** has the smallest with 11 members.

(Table 1: Number of Governing Council Members for each agency)

S/NO	Institution	No. Of Governing Council Members
1.	Pharmacists Council of Nigeria (PCN)	63
2.	Medical and Dental Council of Nigeria (MDCN)	61
3.	Institute of Public Analysts of Nigeria (IPAN)	20
4.	Medical Laboratory Scientists Council of Nigeria (MLSCN)	1
5.	Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria	18
6.	Institute of Chartered Chemists of Nigeria	17
7.	Dental Therapists Registration Board of Nigeria (DTRBN)	17
8.	Medical Rehabilitation Therapists Registration Board of Nigeria (MRTB)	17
9.	Optometrists and Dispensing Opticians Registration Board of Nigeria (ODORBN)	15
10.	Dental Technologists Registration Board of Nigeria (DTRBN)	13
11.	Radiographers Registration Board of Nigeria (RRBN)	12
12.	Health Record Officers Registration Board of Nigeria (HRORBN)	12
13.	Community Health Practitioners Registration Board of Nigeria (CHPRBN)	11

Health Regulatory Agencies and the CRHP

These agencies are tasked with making regulations in accordance with the Acts establishing them, defining and advancing the training and practice of members of their respective professions.

2.0 Setting Up of the Committee of Registrars of the Health Professions (CRHP)

August 19, 2004 is a landmark date for healthcare professions in Nigeria and the West African region. On this day, the then Honourable Minister of Health, **Professor Eyitayo Lambo**, inaugurated the CRHP.

The objectives of the CRHP are to:

- Raise the level of ethical conduct in healthcare delivery in Nigeria;
- Set targets for efficient performance;
- Facilitate Continuing Professional Development (CPD) for health professions;
- Enlighten the general public on health matters;
- Harmonize regulatory activities for efficiency and effectiveness in the diverse health professions;
- Act as a platform for synergy among various government health care efforts by harnessing the unique strengths of different professions; and
- Foster unity and mutual respect among health professions.

During the inauguration, the Minister stated:

“It is heart-warming that the Registrars of all regulatory bodies in the health sector are coming together under one umbrella. This is commendable and should be applauded. I urge you to use this Committee as a springboard to rejuvenate the team spirit that is fast fading away.” (Lambo, 2004)

The expectations from the Registrars are therefore significant. However, they cannot operate independently in regulating health professions. Collaboration, rather than working along parallel tracks, benefits patients and the healthcare system immensely (CRHP, 2008).

Prince Julius Adelusi-Adeluyi, distinguished pharmacist and former Honourable Minister of Health, emphasized during the first CRHP workshop on **July 29, 2008**:

“There is an urgent need for a strong advocacy of harmony among members of the healthcare team.” (CRHP, 2008)

These statements testify to the relevance of this workshop and the chosen theme.

3.0 Activities of the CRHP from Inception to Date

The CRHP members are well-versed in implementing the mandates of their respective Governing Councils/Boards. To enhance cohesion, harmony, and understanding, the Committee designed activities to improve their capacities as Registrars and CEOs. Major activities include:

1. **First Retreat:** Asaba, Delta State (April 10–13, 2008), honoring Dr. Rowland Eyime, then Honourable Commissioner for Science and Technology. Theme: *“Brainstorming on Ways to Improve Health Care Delivery Services in Nigeria.”*
2. **Second Retreat:** Obudu Cattle Ranch and Resort, Cross River State. Prof. W. O. Aiyepoku presented on: *“Empowering Knowledge Workers for Organizational Success: The Advantages of a Knowledge Management-Savvy Workforce.”*
3. **Third Retreat:** Yankari Game Reserve, Bauchi State (January 18–19, 2011), organized by **GSCL Consulting, Abuja**. Theme: *“The Need for Minimum Standards of Practice by Health Regulatory Agencies as an Instrument for Assuring Effective Health Care Regulation in Nigeria.”*
4. **First Workshop:** Sheraton Hotel, Abuja (July 29, 2008). Theme: *“The Role of Health Regulatory Bodies in Advancing Healthcare Delivery Services in Nigeria.”*
5. **Capacity-Building Activities:** Geneva, Switzerland (February 18–19, 2010), attending the Second World Health Professions Conference on Regulations organized by the **World Health Professions Alliance (WHPA)**. Theme: *“Shaping the Future: The Regulation of Health Professionals.”*
6. **Professional Development:** Liverpool Hope University, UK (March 14–25, 2011), attending a **2-week Strategic Development Policy Workshop**.

Healthcare professions and their regulations are dynamic. This fast-changing environment necessitates measurable standards for Councils, Boards, and Institutes to evaluate the quality of the professions they regulate.

4.0 Lessons Learnt

The primary aim of regulatory bodies is to regulate and control the training and practice of their members. In achieving this, the focus has always been to:

- Improve patient health;
- Develop and maintain the healthcare delivery system; and
- Enhance professional competencies and skills through CPD programs.

There are no quick fixes. Health professionals operate interdependently:

- Medical practitioners rely on accurate documentation from Health Record Officers.
- Laboratory Scientists ensure correct diagnosis.
- Nurses rely on Pharmacists for proper drug administration.
- Optometrists coordinate with Ophthalmologists.
- Radiographers provide accurate imaging for surgeons.
- Dental Technologists and Therapists collaborate.
- Community Health Officers make crucial referral decisions in emergencies.
- Chemists ensure proper analysis to prevent harmful interactions.

The proximity of regulatory agencies, such as in the **Federal Capital Territory (FCT), Abuja**, enhances collaboration, particularly where responsibilities overlap.

5.0 Recommendations

5a. Key Recommendations

1. CRHP members should continue organizing activities to foster unity among themselves, their regulatory functions, and the overall interests of patients.
2. CRHP and the Presidents of national health professional associations should meet periodically to improve understanding and elevate healthcare delivery.

3. The Federal Government, via the Ministry of Health, should increase funding to health regulatory agencies.
4. The FCT should allocate suitable land in Abuja for regulatory agencies still operating in Lagos, with financial support from the Ministry of Finance for constructing Headquarters.
5. The Ministry of Health should continue to support CRHP and its members to ensure efficient discharge of responsibilities.

5b. Implementation Strategies

1. Continue organizing workshops and activities to entrench harmony among health professions.
2. CRHP should liaise with national health professional associations to convene periodic meetings.
3. Increase funding for health regulatory agencies during budget cycles.
4. Approve suitable land in Abuja for agencies still based in Lagos to build Head Offices and relocate.
5. The Honourable Minister of Health should continue motivating CRHP members and regulatory bodies for effective performance.

6.0 Conclusion

In conclusion, **Adair's Circle** provides a model for regulatory bodies:

- Achieve their health regulatory mandate;
- Build and maintain the professional health team;
- Develop individual professionals through CPD programs (Weir, 2011).

Effective implementation of these principles ensures the harmony of healthcare professionals and strengthens the overall healthcare delivery system in Nigeria.

Thank you all for listening, and God bless.

References

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